

exclusive relationship. I'm a big fan of all of that. I'm talking about the gamble that is marriage, and the expensive extricating process that is the average vicious divorce. (In fact, here's a brilliant rule of thumb: Don't marry anyone you'd be afraid to divorce.) And remember: Married people do not have a monopoly on soulmates. You don't always *find* your soulmate; as my wife says, you *become* soulmates after building something together over time, which should also include a healthy nest egg.

But maybe you're reading this and thinking the single lifestyle is not for you. After all, there are strong economic incentives to get hitched. It is more expensive to live alone. And studies do show that married couples who stay together build more wealth by the time they reach retirement.

So let's now assume you've had the hard financial discussions, signed a rock-solid prenup, decided you want kids, and therefore want to marry the love of your life. So why did you go and lose your financial mind over the wedding? Who are those four hundred people on the guest list? A horse-drawn carriage? A chocolate fountain? Seriously? And no one's even going to listen to that quartet playing during cocktails. No wonder the average cost of a North American wedding is \$27,000. This figure never fails to stop me in my tracks. It varies by a couple of thousand dollars depending on where you live, but that, dear reader, is insane.

Beyond the colossal amount of money spent on weddings, it's the timing that kills me. When you're young—say, thirty years old or younger—it's the worst time in your life to throw \$27,000 away on a single day. Remember, time is your greatest asset at that stage in life. People who overspend on their weddings are the same whiners who tell me afterward that they can't save enough money for a down payment on a house or pay off their credit card debt. Think about what else that money could do for you. If you invested a lump sum like that at the age of thirty and it earned only 3 percent a year, adding nothing to the principal, it would be worth more than \$75,000 after thirty-five years. At 6 percent compounded interest, that same \$27,000 would be worth more than \$207,000 when you retire!